The scenario: A law firm system

The workflow follows a new client's case from the first inquiry until the firm formally opens, declines or refers the matter.

Environment: The law firm receives prospective clients in two main ways: new clients (walk-ins, phone or online inquiries, and referrals) or existing clients opening a new matter. This scenario mainly focuses on the new-client intake path, starting when the inquiry is received and ending when the matter is opened and assigned to a legal team, declined, or referred to another firm. Existing-client matters exist in the environment but are treated as a separate process that would reuse the same generic TIVIDY mechanisms.

Participants and roles: The main participants focused on include:

- **Intake coordinator (receptionist):** receives the inquiry, captures the client's details and the type of legal problem, and notifies the right practice group.
- **Paralegal:** collects and organises the client's documents, verifies the client's identity and prepares the case file.
- **Compliance officer:** runs the conflict-of-interest check and clears or blocks the matter.
- **Associate attorney:** evaluates the case, decides whether the firm can take it, and drafts the fee estimate and engagement letter.
- **Partner:** gives final approval for accepting the case, especially high-value or high-risk matters and non-standard fee arrangements.
- **Billing clerk:** sets up the client account, issues the retainer invoice and confirms payment.

Major pieces of work:

1. Inquiry received and logged
2. Client details and identity verification
3. Conflict-of-interest check (in parallel with document collection)
4. Collection of the client's supporting documents
5. Preliminary case evaluation by the associate
6. Case acceptance approval
7. Fee estimate and engagement letter
8. Retainer invoice and payment
9. Matter opened and assigned to a legal team (or a non-engagement letter sent)

Decisions and routing points: Deciding the intake route: urgent, with a court date or legal deadline close, or standard. Routing the case to the correct practice area (criminal, family, commercial or litigation). Whether a conflict is found, which leads to decline or to requesting a waiver. Whether the associate accepts the case or escalates it to a more senior attorney. Whether the case is accepted, declined, or referred to another firm.

Approval:

- **Conflict clearance approval:** the compliance officer must clear the conflict check before anyone evaluates the case.
- **Case acceptance approval:** this goes up a chain of authority, from associate to senior associate to partner, depending on the value and risk of the case. If a level doesn't decide within its deadline, the case is passed on to the next level.
- **Fee arrangement approval:** non-standard fees, such as contingency fees or discounted rates, need partner approval before the engagement letter is sent.

Dependencies:

- Case evaluation can't begin until the conflict check is cleared.
- The engagement letter can't be sent until the case has been accepted.
- The matter can't be opened until the client has signed the engagement letter and paid the retainer.
- The conflict check and document collection run in parallel, but both must finish before evaluation.

Failure and exception paths:

- **Conflict of interest found:** the case is declined, or a waiver is requested from the affected parties. If no waiver is given, the workflow ends in a declined outcome.
- **Client's identity can't be verified:** intake is stopped and the client is informed.
- **Client doesn't provide documents within the deadline:** a reminder is sent. If they still aren't received, the intake is closed as withdrawn.
- **An attorney doesn't respond within the deadline:** the approval is escalated to the next level of authority.
- **A legal time limit is about to expire:** the case is marked urgent and escalated straight to a partner.
- **Client doesn't sign or doesn't pay the retainer:** the intake ends in a withdrawn outcome.

External systems:

- **Conflict-check database:** the firm's records of past and current clients and opposing parties, searched during the conflict check.
- **Practice management and billing system:** opens the client account and matter number, issues the retainer invoice and confirms payment.

Expected outcome:

- The matter is opened and assigned to a legal team, declined with a non-engagement letter, referred to another firm, or closed as withdrawn. The full history is recorded and archived for compliance and future reference.
